

you about the functions. This kind of menu is visually appealing, and Nokia loyalty-switchers shouldn't find it hard to get accustomed to.

The screen is one more aspect of this phone that should appeal to many. The 64K colour screen is fantastic in terms of colour saturation, and images look vivid and life-like. The animated wallpapers make great use of the screen.

Connectivity options are via infra-red and serial cable. The cable is provided with the set. The sync software is simple and elegant, but could be better. Java games can also be installed using the provided software. Some are provided on the CD-ROM.

The reception quality was reasonably okay and voice was clear, but at times there was noticeable cracking of speech. The battery lasts around two and half days, which we think is a bit low.



Sony Ericsson Z600

Price: Rs 17,000 **B-**

The sheer looks of the Z600 with its changeable covers are enough to make you want to hold it! The mirror-finish cover sports attractive colours and catchy patterns, which makes this phone stand out from the crowd. The keys are well laid-out, sufficiently big, and have enough space between them to facilitate error-free phone number and message typing.

This phone is, however, bigger than other flip phones and feels bulky. It's uncomfortable to carry in your shirt pocket, and it's more comfortable using it hands-free.

The menu of the phone is not different from other Sony Ericsson phones. It has self-explanatory icons and a user-friendly, linear menu style. There are a total of 16 icons displayed on the 65K colour screen, which are crisp and visible in daylight as well.

The camera on this phone is better than those of others in its class. The camera lens is on the edge of the flip, which helps you click snaps. You can click at 288 x 352 or 120 x 160. Images are stored in the JPEG format. They can be transferred to a PC using the cable or Bluetooth, or to other phones using infrared. The phone has 1,851 KB of space for photos and Java applications.

A big minus on this phone is that you first need to copy contacts from the SIM to the Phonebook before you can search for contacts.

The Z600 is priced at Rs 17,000, and on the whole, provides good features for the price.



Panasonic X66

Price: Rs 13,400 **B**

The X66 is a cute, chubby, visually toned-down version of the X70. It is quite compact, but not sleek. Despite its size, the X66 packs in a camera and a very good colour display. Priced at Rs 13,400, the X66 is quite a good buy.

This blue X66 that we reviewed does not look as good as the X70, but is reasonably attractive. It lacks an external LCD display, but to compensate, it has a multi-colour LED integrated, which blinks in different colours: it blinks red for voice calls, goes blue for SMS, turns red again if there are unread messages, and so on.

The keys sport a blue backlight that does a decent job of highlighting the keys. A four-direction jog-dial helps browse the menu. The keys are super-responsive, and the ergonomics are perfect; typing messages on this phone is pure delight. In fact, it's the keys that make this phone a pleasure to use.

The 64K colour screen is relatively small, but colour saturation and vividness is perfect. The screen looks great indoors, but gets dark outdoors, making it difficult to read.

Menu grouping takes some time to get used to especially if you are a Nokia user, but once you're used to it, things are a breeze. Icons are self-explanatory. One particular feature that is unique to Panasonic is that

you can set the phone to switch on or off automatically after a specific period.

The integrated camera has a small mirror for a self-portrait. Basic functionality is what you get with this camera, but it does include a 'night' mode. The pics we got were okay, but not anywhere near the ones we shot using the Samsung X600. Ringtones are pretty standard, but they aren't loud enough to be audible in noisy places. You transfer images via infrared.

The games provided should keep you busy. There's an inbuilt Slots game. Signal reception is fairly good, voice clarity is okay, and so is the battery life—three days with normal use.



Motorola V878

Price: Rs 20,495 **C**

The V878 is priced at Rs 20,495, which is a little too high for this phone, as it doesn't have upgradeable memory, nor does it have infrared or Bluetooth.

The phone sports a dual-tone body with a strong flip. The keys offer good tactile feel, but because of the box design, you might want to hold the phone in one hand and dial numbers with the other.

Typing SMSes using the iTap method is a little different with this phone, as it needs you to select the word from a list. It doesn't automatically predict it. As an example, when we typed 'have', we were presented with 'gave'. Here 'have' was the second option; we had to select it from the list before proceeding further.

The Voice Note feature allows for 30 seconds of recording. Recording quality was decent. Menu navigation is simple. The animated icons are self explanatory, but the placement of icons is not great.

The phone is Java-enabled, and the bundled software is interactive and helpful. Once the phone is detected on a PC and installed, it can be used as a GPRS modem. Using software, you can send and receive e-mails, and send and view messages. You can also download images and short movies from the phone to the computer. However, the reverse is not possible.

The camera on this phone isn't too good. Pictures were dark and unclear. However it allows for four resolution settings—